

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

1 Chronicles

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The books of 1–2 Chronicles were written to inspire hope. Exile from the land God promised had taken away Israel's wealth. When the people returned to the land, their neighbors opposed them. The people were discouraged. Many no longer cared about rebuilding their life together.

The Chronicler (the writer of 1–2 Chronicles) wrote to show that the people were still connected to their past. He arranged Israel's history in a way that helped the people understand their present life. He believed that Judea, his community, had an important role in the kingdom of God. The people needed to remember who they were so they could fulfill God's purpose for them.

Setting

The Babylonians conquered the kingdom of Judah between 605 and 586 BC. Within one generation, Babylon became weak because of problems inside the empire (see Daniel 5). At the same time, Cyrus the Great, the king of Persia, was building a new empire in the east. Cyrus ruled from 559 to 530 BC. His empire joined the Medes and Persians into one kingdom. In October 539 BC, Babylon surrendered without a fight. Cyrus's empire then grew west and included Babylonia (see Daniel 5:30–31).

Cyrus followed his usual policy for conquered peoples. He allowed the Jewish exiles to return to Judea. They could form a province around the city of Jerusalem. The books of Ezra and Nehemiah describe this time. The prophets Haggai and Zechariah also speak about it. The Jewish community began to worship God again. They gained some protection and some economic freedom. But they had almost no hope of ruling themselves.

The community was surrounded by enemies. It was very different from the former kingdom of Judah. As the people rebuilt the temple and later the wall of Jerusalem, nearby peoples mocked them and opposed their work. The Jewish people struggled to keep their identity, faith, and way of life. Social and political powers around them threatened to make them part of other peoples. They needed purpose and hope.

At this time, the people of Judea faced serious questions:

- How could they stay faithful to the faith of their ancestors while living under a powerful empire?
- How could they be the people of God while another nation ruled over them?
- What did God's promise about David's eternal kingdom mean in these circumstances?

Later, during the Greek and Roman periods, some Jews answered these questions through strong national loyalty. Groups such as the Maccabees and the zealots in the New Testament period wanted to rebel and gain independence. Other Jews believed they could not escape life under empire. They focused on covenant faithfulness, which means remaining loyal to God and his binding agreement with his people. The book of 1 Chronicles was written to address these questions and concerns.

Summary

The text of 1 Chronicles has two main parts:

- The first part uses genealogies, or family lists, to show Israel's identity (1 Chronicles 1:1–9:44).
- The second part tells how David prepared Jerusalem for the temple and for Solomon's rule (10:1–29:30).

The first chapter is a genealogy that follows the family line of people God chose, from Adam to Jacob, who was also called Israel (chapter 1).

Chapters 2–8 describe the Israelites from Jacob to the exile in Babylon. This section begins with the tribe of Judah (chapters 2–4). The family of David appears near the middle of this section (chapter 3).

Then the text describes the other tribes of Israel (chapters 5–7). This includes the tribes east of the Jordan River, in the region called Transjordan. Levi appears at the center of these family lists (chapter 6). Levi was an important tribe because Israel's priests and temple workers came from it. The record then continues with the tribe of Benjamin (chapter 8). The family lists continue down to about 400 BC. They end with a list of key leaders from the community that returned from exile and began to rebuild Jerusalem (chapter 9).

Saul's family history introduces the beginning of the kingdom of Israel (9:35–44). After Saul died because he was unfaithful to God, David became king (10:1–14; 11:1–12:40). The chapters about David's rule explain how he organized officials and prepared for the temple (chapters 13–27). One major event was bringing the ark of the covenant to Jerusalem (chapters 13–16). The ark was a sacred chest that represented God's presence with Israel.

The rest of 1 Chronicles describes the steps toward building the temple. These chapters include:

- the identify of the builder (chapter 17),
- the political conditions needed for the work (chapters 18–20),
- the temple site (chapter 21),
- the workers (chapters 23–27), and
- the materials and plans (chapters 22, 28–29).

The account of David's rule as king ends with a large public gathering. At this gathering, Solomon is appointed as king. He will be the king of peace who builds the temple (chapters 28–29).

Author and Date

According to tradition, Ezra wrote the books of Chronicles. But the writer does not tell us his name. The Chronicler lived in or near Jerusalem. He strongly supported the temple and its services. He often gives special attention to the Levites, the tribe that served in the temple. This may suggest that the writer was a Levite. It may also explain how he had access to the records he used to write his history.

The Chronicler wrote near the end of the Persian Empire, probably around 400 BC. The list of Jehoiachin's descendants suggests this date (3:17–24). The list goes about eight generations after Zerubbabel. Zerubbabel served as governor around 520 BC, during the rule of Darius, king of Persia (Zechariah 1:1; 4:9).

The Chronicler probably wrote after Nehemiah went to Jerusalem. Nehemiah went there in the twentieth year of Artaxerxes, in 445 BC. He went to repair the city walls (Nehemiah 2:1). Chronicles was probably not written as late as the Greek period. That period began with Alexander the Great in 332 BC. The book does not show signs of Greek language or Greek ideas.

For these reasons, a date around 400 BC is likely.

Historical Situation

We know little about life in Judea after Nehemiah. But the book of Nehemiah shows some of the community's problems. Many people were tempted to marry people outside Israel. These mixed marriages still happened in Malachi's time, in the 400s BC (see Malachi 2:14–16). Marrying foreigners could give people access to land and wealth that they could not gain within the Jewish community.

But this practice went against the law, which Ezra brought back with him from Babylon. Ezra and Nehemiah taught the Jews to remain separate from the surrounding peoples and to depend on their own com-

munity. This teaching made the surrounding peoples angry. Their anger grew as the Jews tried to make the temple the center of their social and economic life again.

Genre and Composition

The title of Chronicles also shows what kind of writing it is. In Hebrew, the title means "the events of the days." This means the book records important events.

Jerome, an early Christian Bible scholar, called Chronicles *chronikon* in his introduction to the Latin translation of Samuel and Kings. *Chronikon* means "annals," or a written record of events from the past. In other words, Chronicles is written as a history.

The Greek translation of the Old Testament, called the Septuagint, gave Chronicles a different title. It called the book "the leftover things." This title treated Chronicles as a second book that simply added missing details to 1–2 Kings. The Chronicler probably would not have agreed with this view. Chronicles is not just a supplement to 1–2 Kings. It is a unique work that uses many different sources.

As he wrote this history, the Chronicler arranged Israel's past to help his readers find meaning and value in their own time. He included genealogies because they answered two important questions about history: Whose story should be told? Where did these people live? The Chronicler explains why a people with little power or public honor believed their life and way of life mattered deeply for the future.

The book of 1 Chronicles covers the same time period as 2 Samuel. There are many similar passages in both books. But the authors had different purposes in writing. We can see these differences by comparing the passages that describe the same events.

Meaning and Message

God's promise to David is at the center of the message of Chronicles (17:1–27). David wanted to build a house for the ark of the covenant. But Nathan the prophet received a vision. God showed him that David had misunderstood the plan. David would not build a house for God. Instead, God would build a house for David. This "house" meant a dynasty, or a family line of kings (2 Samuel 7:11–14; 1 Chronicles 17:10–14).

God's eternal kingdom would come through David's family line. Psalm 2 shows the importance of this promise. The nations rejected God's kingdom and tried to rule for themselves. But God had already chosen his king on Mount Zion. This king would defeat the nations and receive the earth as his inheritance.

The Chronicler took this promise very seriously. God's kingdom would come through the promised son of David. The community around Jerusalem represented that promised kingdom and the hope for the future.

The Chronicler had two tasks:

1. He needed to explain why the kingdom of David had failed.
2. He needed to show that this small and weak province in the powerful Persian Empire would become the kingdom God had promised to David.

The explanation begins with Saul's failure. God rejected Saul as king over Israel because Saul was unfaithful. He did not obey God. He also broke the covenant by asking a medium (a person who tries to speak with the dead) for help (10:13).

Later kings made the same kind of mistake. They rebelled against God's covenant. They looked for safety from foreign powers and false gods instead of trusting the Lord, their Rock (see Deuteronomy 32:4, 15–39). For this reason, unfaithfulness is an important theme in Chronicles. The writer uses this idea to explain why God judged Saul and later kings of Judah.

The reason for hope comes from Solomon's prayer when he dedicated the temple. God said,

“if My people who are called by My name humble themselves and pray and seek My face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven, forgive their sin, and heal their land” (2 Chronicles 7:14).

This promise reminds the people what restoration requires. They must humble themselves, pray, seek God, and turn away from sin. Then God will forgive them and heal their land.

The book of 1 Chronicles gives the reasons why Israel could hope for restoration. The promise God made to David did not disappear during the exile. The community that returned to Jerusalem still carried that promise. Even when the kingdom divided after Solomon's rule, the tribes were not cut off from Israel's future. For the Chronicler, all the tribes were part of the restoration. This included the tribes of the northern kingdom (see 1 Chronicles 9:3).

The Chronicler understood Israel as a people of faith, not as a political nation. In his day, Israel was not an independent kingdom. It was a small ethnic province in the powerful Persian Empire. Even so, the Chronicler wanted to show that the unity begun under David and Solomon had continued. He also wanted to show that

God's promise to David still gave the people hope for the future.